

Website Reviews

With the advent of the Internet, there is so much information on the World Wide Web (WWW) that it is difficult to discern what is ultimately real, virtually real, or just gossip. Perhaps more than any other source of information, their authenticity, applicability, authorship, bias, and usability matter. It is an info-glut and info-garbage of cyberspace, making it difficult to evaluate information sources and content. When thinking critically about discipline-based resources, particularly in the field of education, both faculty and students need to be able to evaluate a web page for authenticity, applicability, authorship, bias, and usability. The ability to critically evaluate information is an important skill for leaders, educators, researchers, faculty, and students. This is an essential skill in this information age.

The World Wide Web is a knowledge base for exploring the world and contains a vast amount of information, but not all sources are equally valuable or reliable. Thinking critically about its resources, there are many guidelines, and yes, there is a web page evaluating another web page that is offering some basic points to consider (see references below). Like any guideline, these are just some common rules, tips, and tricks to follow. Perhaps each researcher needs to define their own best practices for reviewing a website. Before deciding or basing it on the information available, researchers (and leaders, educators, students) will consider the following criteria: reliability, accuracy, authority, currency, fairness, adequacy, efficiency, and organization [13]. Both educators and students need to learn to apply these concepts critically to the sites they visit so they become thoughtful and discerning consumers of information.

Definition

Accuracy

Are these real numbers and facts? Do they match reality? How do we know they are real and on target?

Currency

How recent are the facts and figures? Were they gathered ten years ago? Do they tell us? Does it matter? Might crime or employment have changed since then?

Authority

Do they have any credentials to provide this information? Any evidence of training or professional skill? Do they identify the author or provider by name? Who did this work?

Fairness

Have they presented the material selectively or in an unbalanced manner? Is there bias or slanting in the reporting? Did they leave some information out? Did they focus only on the positive? The negative?

Adequacy

Do they tell you enough? Do they provide sufficient data or evidence? Do they go into enough detail and depth?

Efficiency

Can you find what you need at this site relatively quickly or is it loaded down with graphics and elements, which prolong your visit and your search unnecessarily?

Organization

Is the information laid out in a logical fashion so that you can easily locate what you need without wandering around and wasting time?

The article from "The Educational Technology Journal, Vol 6, No 9, June 1997", using a table as a "visual organizer" often helps focus the evaluation of sources. List the site or source at the top and then rate each source from four asterisks to one asterisk. Here are some points to consider regarding Web sites for subject disciplines [13].

**** Excellent *** Good ** Satisfactory * Weak

	Source One http://www.naspa.org	Source Two http://www.acpa.nche.edu	Source Three
Reliability, Accuracy, Authority	- Focus on student learning outcome, - Faculty development, - Institution development - Definition of the role of institution, - Vision of the future, - Can't evaluate due to most of the info is based on members-only access, - Promote diversity Rate: ****	* No mission statement; no clue of why they exist	TBD
Currency	Professional classes are up to date on current issues in re-education. Rate: ****	* Most info within different committees is old	TBD
Fairness	Can't evaluate; members-only access	*	TBD
Adequacy	Can't evaluate; members only access	*	TBD
Efficiency, Organization	Good organization Rate: ****	Efficiency = *, most links don't work Organization = **	TBD

Conclusion

In closing, I think this is a very important exercise for researchers (leaders, educators, students). As a researcher, one needs not only the ability to gather information but also the ability to assess the validity of the source, wherever it comes from. The Internet contains information on almost any topic you can imagine; that information may be misleading or seemingly not true—one just needs to use the information wisely and ethically. Along with the courtesy of information comes great responsibility and the need for great care to safeguard the authenticity of the sources and their owners.

References

For additional information and resources to support the development of Web site evaluation skills, visit the following sites:

1. Template from the USC library to help structure Web site reviews, <http://www.usc.edu/users/help/flick/Infofilter/template.html>
2. Beyond "Cool" - Analog Models for Reviewing Digital Resources by James Rettig - ONLINE, September 1996, <http://www.onlineinc.com/onlinemag/SeptOL/rettig9.html>
3. Cornell Library, <http://urisref.library.cornell.edu/skill26.htm>
4. Karen McLachlan, Library Media Specialist at East Knox High School, Ohio, developed these guides to use with teachers and students to evaluate content and graphic design of home pages. WWW CyberGuide Ratings for Content Evaluation - A guide for rating the curriculum content on websites. WWW CyberGuide Ratings for Web Site Design - A guide for rating the design of a web site. <http://www.cyberbee.com/guides.html>
5. A paper explores the relevance of existing criteria for other formats, the continuum of information on the net, and the current state of evaluation, tools on the net. By Hope N. Tillman, Director of Libraries, Babson College, and Babson Park, MA. <http://www.tiac.net/users/hope/findqual.html>
6. Web resources from Widener University/Wolfgram Memorial Library: PowerPoint presentation, techniques and a bibliography of other sources. <http://www.science.widener.edu/%7ewithers/webeval.htm>
7. A brief list of good evaluation questions to ask of any Web site. From Lehigh University Library. <http://www.lib.lehigh.edu/evaluating.web.html>
8. The Library at Purdue offers the Internet Evaluator Checklist. <http://thorplus.lib.purdue.edu/research/classes/gs175/3gs175/evaluation.html>
9. The ALA sponsored Evaluation Criteria Rating System for Web Sites - a form that sets up rating criteria in six sections: Authority, Design/Style, Navigation, Content, Performance, and Curriculum Connections. <http://www.icconnect-online.org>
10. Kathy offers three surveys ... one for elementary, one for middle school, and one for high school. She also offers a rich bibliography. <http://www.capecod.net/schrockguide/eval.htm>
11. Carolyn Caywood provides strong questions to guide thinking about ACCESS, DESIGN and CONTENT. <http://www6.pilot.infi.net/%7ecarolyn/criteria.html>
12. UCLA College Library. CONTENT. STRUCTURE. SOURCE by Esther Grassian. <http://www.library.ucla.edu/libraries/college/instruct/critical.htm>
13. Comparing & Evaluating Web Information Sources, <http://www.fno.org/jun97/eval.html>